I said that in our correspondence both of us had expressed a desire for better Soviet-American relations, but that it was being jeopardized by “political terror, mass arrests and bloodshed in Poland . . . the Soviet Union must decide whether we can move ahead with this agenda [of trying to improve relations] or whether we will travel a different path.”

On Christmas morning, after we’d opened our gifts around the family tree in the White House, I was handed a reply to my message to Brezhnev, a terse note sent via the Molink claiming it was the United States, not his country, that was interfering in Polish affairs.

“If a frank exchange of opinion between Communist parties and the expressions by them of their opinions to each other is not pleasing to someone in the United States,” Brezhnev said, “then, in reply, we must firmly say: That is the business of the parties themselves and only them. And the Polish people do not sit in judgment of others who would force their values on them.” Apparently referring to several recent speeches I had made, Brezhnev accused me of “defaming our social and state system, our internal order,” a charge to which I pleaded guilty.

> Attempts to dictate your will to other states are in gross contradiction to the elementary norms of international law. I would like to say further: they are thoroughly amoral. And no sort of game with words regarding the rights of man can hide this fact. The Soviet Union repudiates the claims of anyone to interfere in the events occurring in Poland. You, Mr. President, hint that if further events in Poland should develop in a manner unsatisfactory to the United States damage will be inflicted along the entire range of Soviet-American relations. But if we are to speak frankly, it is your Administration that has already done enough to disrupt or at the very least undermine